

4.2 Language and the self

Paper 4 Language Topics · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Language choices help construct identity, relationships and stance. A speaker may shift style between peer group, classroom and workplace without possessing a single “real” voice. Analyse pronouns, address, code choice, politeness and evaluative vocabulary. Ethical interpretation requires attention to context and avoiding assumptions about background.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

“Could you send the draft by Friday?” may index workplace politeness; “send it tonight?” could index familiarity. Neither phrasing alone proves age or class.

Original practice stimulus

Message to a friend: “Hey, got the notes? Missed the last bit when the bell went. Send a photo if you can :)” Message to a teacher: “Dear Ms Lee, I was absent for the final ten minutes of class. Could you please share the notes or let me know which pages we should read? Thank you, Sam.” Both messages ask for access to the same material. The first uses an elliptical question and an emoticon; the second supplies a reason and an alternative request. The writer may have adjusted to the audience and medium rather than expressing two fixed identities.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 A student writes “Hey, got the notes?” to a friend and “Dear Ms Lee, could you share the notes?” to a teacher. Analyse how language marks relationship and a limit of the inference.

[25]

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong answer contrasts greeting, elliptical syntax and politeness with formal address and modal request; links choices to audience and situation while noting that two messages do not prove a fixed personal identity.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: English Language 9093, 2024–2026.
<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/635901-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.